

MANDAR DEODHAR



RAJESH MEHTA, 26

DESIGNATION:

Career Development Programme Manager, IBM Global

ACADEMIC

QUALIFICATION:

MA from TISS

"In India hiring the disabled is to merely fulfil corporate social responsibility."

PRANAV LAL, 29

DESIGNATION:

Associate Consultant Mahindra Special Services Group

ACADEMIC

QUALIFICATION:

B.Com and MBA

"I always wanted to fight cyber crime so I joined this company."

converts the image to text and then to voice, such that he can hear what is contained in the document. "Now you know how I know exactly what I am signing on, nobody can take me for a ride just because I cannot see."

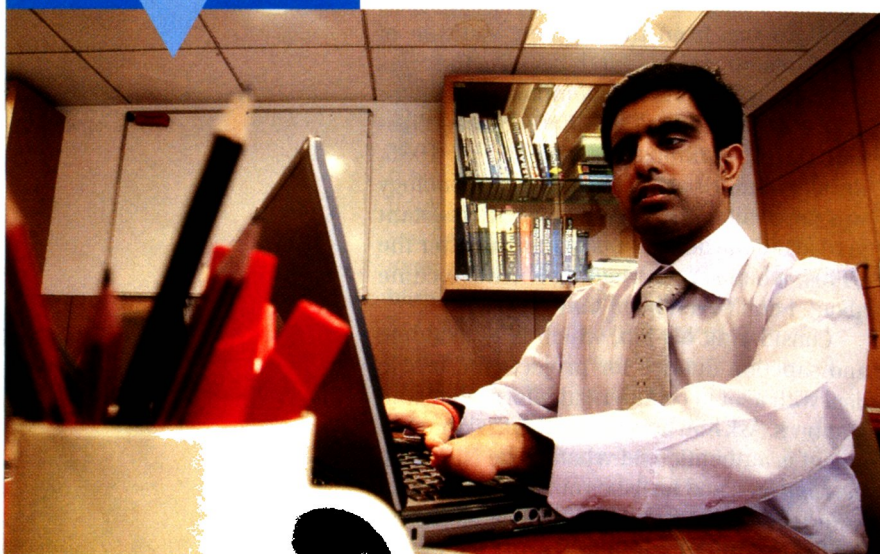
While there are companies like IDBI and IBM, which have taken a bet on professionals going by their calibre, others like Tata Indicom are actively working with the National Association for the Blind to facilitate employment for such people by launching "Drishti Call Centre", operated by visually challenged persons. Employees at the call centre make out-bound calls to market the telecom company's schemes in north India. Special software Navigation & Expert Interaction Logic (NEIL) or Interactive Voice Responses (IVR) is used to transform data from text to voice. The agents are paid Rs 3 per successful call and they earn Rs 5,000-6,000 per month.

Opportunities are not restricted to large

corporations alone. Technology has enabled Kanchan Pamnani to run a successful legal practice in Mumbai and her client list boasts of blue-chips. Says Pamnani, a solicitor and advocate: "Technology and my career saved me." Pamnani begins her day by visiting the Bombay High Court website to see if her cases are up for hearing on that day. She is fast, if not faster, than any other average Internet user.

There are, however, hurdles that remain. Buying insurance, opening a bank account and sitting for competitive exams is still a distant dream in India. Currently, there are no uniform policies in the country for people with disabilities for written exams. All those with visual disability appearing for an exam don't have the liberty to choose their scribes, who have to be junior to them academically so as to prevent any kind of manipulation during the exam. Candidates are not given a choice on the mode of exam as some are proficient with the computer while others may want to use Braille or scribes. Despite inclusive educational policies, B-schools routinely turn away candidates with visual disability and don't give any extra time during competitive entrance exams. Recalls Mohammad Asif, a senior consultant with PricewaterhouseCoopers (PwC) in Kolkata: "I was grilled for two hours during my interview with Symbiosis Centre for Management and HRD, where I was asked how I would cope with the course." It was easier getting a job with PwC, which facilitated his functioning through technology. Today, Asif is helping companies with organisational structure and design.

Clearly, there's a long way to go before the visually challenged can achieve a greater level of equality but the growing number of inspirational success stories should help in shortening that journey.



RAVI S SAHNI